SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #6 · WEALTH AND PRIVILEGE

“I earned everything; others just didn't try.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A family that prized hard work, a career that rewarded effort, or a community that looked down on struggle can teach us that success is simply the result of trying. Because effort really does matter, the belief feels true. What it leaves out is the help, health, timing, opportunity, and gifts that came from outside us, and the hardships other people carry that we cannot see.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture honors diligence. Proverbs says diligent hands bring profit. But Scripture also says that every good gift comes from God, and Moses warned Israel not to say, “The power and strength of my hands have made this wealth for me,” because it is the Lord who gives the power to gain wealth. Paul asks, “What do you have that you did not receive?” These passages do not tell us to feel guilty for working hard or for having something. They invite thankfulness, humility, and open hands toward those who have less.

> *“You might say in your heart, ‘The power and strength of my hands have made this wealth for me.’ But remember that it is the LORD your God who gives you the power to gain wealth, in order to confirm His covenant that He swore to your fathers even to this day”* (Deuteronomy 8:17–18).

Also see

> “For who makes you so superior? What do you have that you did not receive? And if you did receive it, why do you boast as though you did not?” (1 Corinthians 4:7).

> “Every good and perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of the heavenly lights, with whom there is no change or shifting shadow” (James 1:17).

> “The rich and the poor have this in common: The LORD is Maker of them all” (Proverbs 22:2).

> “The earth is the LORD’s, and the fullness thereof, the world and all who dwell therein” (Psalm 24:1).

Common self-statements

- Anyone who really tried would have what I have.
- People who struggle brought it on themselves.
- I did this on my own.
- I do not owe anyone anything.
- If they wanted it, they would have worked harder.
- Being generous would only reward laziness.

Common logical errors

- Fundamental attribution error: Crediting my results to effort alone and other people’s results to their flaws.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that people either earn what they have or deserve what they lack.
- Mental filter: Remembering my effort and overlooking the help, health, and opportunities I received.
- Overgeneralizing: Judging everyone who struggles by what I assume about a few.

Challenging questions

- What help, timing, health, or opportunity did I receive that I did not earn?
- Who taught me, hired me, or gave me a chance?
- What hidden burdens could someone else be carrying that I cannot see?
- What do I have that I did not receive?
- How would my view of others change if I held success more loosely?
- What is one way I can use what I have to bless someone else?

Truth summary

> Effort matters, and I can be glad about work well done. But everything I have, including my health, my abilities, and my opportunities, came through God's hand and the help of others. I can be thankful instead of proud, and generous instead of judging.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Humility
- Pride
- Thankful
- Giving
- Riches, True

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Pride
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Good Good Father — Chris Tomlin
God's fatherly love is deeper than human approval or achievement.

Thrive — Casting Crowns
Life rooted in God includes purposeful growth and joy, not merely surviving or staying busy.

Forever — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

To God Be the Glory — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn celebrates redemption and forgiveness through Christ.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I earned everything; others just didn't try"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I earned everything; others just didn't try." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did I receive that I did not earn?
- ☐ Who helped me along the way?
- ☐ What might this person be carrying that I cannot see?
- ☐ What would thankfulness look like today?
- ☐ How can I use what I have to help someone?
- ☐ Where has pride shaped how I see others?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Hard work matters, and so does grace.
- ☐ Everything I have is a gift to be stewarded.
- ☐ I do not know what others carry.
- ☐ Thankfulness makes me more generous.
- ☐ God, not my effort, gives the power to get wealth.
- ☐ I can honor my work and still stay humble.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Deuteronomy 8:17–18**
  "You might say in your heart, 'The power and strength of my hands have made this wealth for me.' But remember that it is the LORD your God who gives you the power to gain wealth, in order to confirm His covenant that He swore to your fathers even to this day."
- ☐ **1 Corinthians 4:7**
  "For who makes you so superior? What do you have that you did not receive? And if you did receive it, why do you boast as though you did not?"
- ☐ **James 1:17**
  "Every good and perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of the heavenly lights, with whom there is no change or shifting shadow."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ What I received: Each evening, write one thing today that came from someone else's help or from God's provision, and one thing you did yourself.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Deuteronomy 8:18 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God gives me the power to work, so I can be thankful, humble, and generous.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Humility" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ List five gifts you did not earn. Include people who helped you, abilities you were born with, and opportunities that came your way.
- ☐ Thank someone who helped you. Write or say a specific thank-you to one person who made a difference in your path.
- ☐ Ask a question instead of making a judgment. Next time you assume someone "just didn't try," ask a kind question about their story and listen.
- ☐ Give one planned gift. Choose an amount you are comfortable with and give it to someone in need, quietly.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I earned everything; others just didn't try": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A gift I received
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I earned everything; others just didn't try.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, every good gift comes from You. Forgive me for the pride that says I did it all myself. Make me thankful, humble, and generous toward people who carry burdens I cannot see. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.